Introducing the Team Functional Canvas

A practical, accessible guide to describing Team Architecture and improving Team Intelligence

Better Team Intelligence starts with a shared, structured understanding of how the team works.

Team Intelligence

Team Intelligence is the collective capability of a team to understand its situation, make sound decisions, perform work, learn and adapt toward shared outcomes. It depends on more than individual expertise. It also depends on shared context: purpose, boundaries, rules, knowledge, roles, resources, relationships and work.

When that context is fragmented, undocumented or understood differently by different people, the team relies on assumptions and personal memory. The same problem limits the safe and useful application of AI. Improving Team Intelligence therefore begins by making the team's architecture visible and connected.

What is the Team Functional Canvas?

The Team Functional Canvas, or TFC, is a structured blueprint for how a team is designed, operates and delivers value. It brings the most important parts of the team into one coherent model so that people, leaders, stakeholders and authorised AI can work from a consistent understanding.

TEAM DESIGN	TEAM ENVIRONMENT	TEAM DELIVERY
What the team is and why it exists	**The conditions surrounding the team**	**The capability that turns intent into results**
Foundation, Mission, Operating System	Rules, Stakeholders, Communication, Knowledge	Roles, Resources, Tasks

What the TFC helps you do

- Create a shared description of the team's purpose, mandate, scope and boundaries.
- Connect organisational value and desired outcomes to the work the team performs.
- Clarify roles, decision rights, governance, stakeholders and handovers.
- Identify the knowledge, systems, tools and other resources needed for delivery.
- Make gaps, overlaps, constraints, dependencies and single points of failure visible.
- Provide structured organisational context for responsible human and AI-supported work.

The ten parts of the canvas

1.1 Team Foundation	Identity, mandate, services, scope and boundaries.
1.2 Team Mission	Purpose, outcomes, value drivers and measures of success.
1.3 Team Operating System	How work flows, decisions are made and the team responds to changing conditions.
2.1 Team Rules	Governance, controls, authorities, obligations and approvals.
2.2 Stakeholders	Who the team serves, depends upon, influences and affects.
2.3 Communication Protocol	How information, consultation, decisions and coordination flow.
2.4 Team Knowledge Base	The knowledge, information, terminology and expertise required.
3.1 Team Roles	The roles, competencies, authorities and human capability needed.
3.2 Team Resources	Systems, data, tools, methods, equipment, facilities and AI capability.
3.3 Team Tasks	The significant work that connects the mission to execution.

How to use the TFC

1. Define the team

Agree which team is being described and the level at which the canvas will operate.

2. Start with purpose and boundaries

Describe why the team exists, what it provides, what is in scope and what is not.

3. Describe how the team works

Capture the operating rhythms, decision arrangements, governance and key interfaces.

4. Connect capability to work

Identify the roles, knowledge and resources required for significant tasks.

5. Test the connections

Check that outcomes have tasks, tasks have owners, and critical work has adequate knowledge, resources, controls and continuity.

6. Validate with the right people

Confirm important assumptions, authorities and requirements with accountable owners and authoritative sources.

7. Keep it current

Review the canvas when the team's purpose, scope, structure, systems, governance or work changes.

Ways it can be applied

- Team design or redesign
- Onboarding and role clarity
- Operating-model and cross-team alignment
- Governance, assurance and risk reviews
- Knowledge and capability planning
- Process and task improvement
- Business continuity and succession planning
- Preparing teams for responsible AI and automation

What good looks like

A useful TFC is concise enough to understand, but specific enough to guide decisions and expose gaps. It describes the team as it actually operates, not only as policies or organisation charts suggest. Important statements are traceable to evidence, and assumptions or unknowns remain visible until validated.

The TFC is not the organisation chart. It is the connected architecture of purpose, environment, capability and work.

One-page canvas

Use the one-page canvas as the shared visual summary. Supporting detail can be developed separately where needed.

